

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

EMIL JONES III TRIAL

Legislator takes stand in his own defense

Decision to testify in corruption case a risk for sitting elected official

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

State Sen. Emil Jones III stood Tuesday in a gray suit and paced, taking a sip of water, tapping on a table, even stifling a loud, seemingly nervous yawn.

But Jones, the son of former Senate President Emil Jones Jr., wasn't preparing for some big speech in Springfield. Instead, he was about to take a federal witness stand in Chicago in his own bribery trial, rolling the dice before a jury that could make him the first sitting state legislator to be convicted of corruption in nearly a decade.

With several relatives looking on, including his stepmother and brother, Jones, a South Side Democrat, strode to the stand in U.S. District Judge Andrea Wood's 21st floor courtroom and introduced himself to the jury in a loud, deep voice, telling them his namesake father, who spent nearly 40 years in the General Assembly before retiring in 2008, inspired him to go into politics.

"Ever since I was a child, I always wanted to be a state senator like my father and I decided to run," Jones told the jury, leaving out that his father orchestrated a time-honored Illinois political maneuver to make it happen, retiring abruptly after winning the primary and pitching his son as his replacement to favorable Democratic committeemen.

Jones told the jury he's run unopposed ever since winning that first election. Asked by his attorney, Victor Henderson, if he still had to raise money, Jones said, "I never had an election. I never had an opponent to run against. So ... no."

But he still had a fund, Friends

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Former President Joe Biden speaks Tuesday during the Advocates, Counselors, and Representatives for the Disabled bipartisan conference at the Sofitel Chicago Magnificent Mile. It was his first major speaking appearance since leaving office in January. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Biden hits Trump for 'damage,' 'destruction'

In Chicago speech, ex-president claims threat of Social Security cuts creating psychological fear

By Rick Pearson
Chicago Tribune

Former President Joe Biden sought Tuesday to use an audience in Chicago of national advocates for the disabled to reestablish himself as a leading party voice to challenge the actions of President Donald Trump amid listless Democratic leadership in taking on Biden's successor in the White House.

"Look what's happening. In fewer than 100 days this administration has done so much damage

and so much destruction," Biden said, citing Trump administration-ordered job cuts in the Social Security Administration.

In his first major speaking appearance since leaving office in January, Biden spoke for nearly a half hour before about 130 members of Advocates, Counselors, and Representatives for the Disabled at a downtown Chicago hotel. He never used Trump's name. But he frequently assailed the current administration and contended it was creating "profound" psychological fears

among the elderly over potential cuts and access to Social Security disability benefits.

"The psychological effect is profound," Biden said. "Many of these beneficiaries, it's their only income. If it were cut or taken away, the psychological pressure by having this debate is absolutely devastating."

Trump has promised not to cut Social Security benefits as part of plans to find savings in the federal budget in part to extend tax cuts granted during his first term. But Republicans who control

Congress are under pressure to find savings, fueling Democratic warnings about distrust of Trump and that Social Security and Medicaid, health care for the poor, could be on the chopping block.

Recounting some of the familiar family phrases he frequently used during his aborted reelection campaign, Biden asked of Republicans, "What the hell are they thinking?" in considering any reduction of benefits for the

Turn to Speech, Page 2

AI-powered cameras may come to Lake Shore Drive

Lawmaker calls for study in effort to make roadway safer

By Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

Shortly after starting his midnight shift as a doorman at a Gold Coast high-rise a few years ago, Julian Fuentes heard a screech on nearby DuSable Lake Shore Drive. As he and some residents streamed outside to investigate, he said, he saw a car on its side and a fiery wreck.

"You can kind of feel the ground kind of shake a little bit," Fuentes said. "Unfortunately, it's one of those situations where you kind of think to yourself, 'Not again.'"



Julian Fuentes stands outside the building where he works in the 1500 block of North DuSable Lake Shore Drive. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE**

The fatal November 2021 collision was one of the more traumatic crashes Fuentes said he's witnessed on DuSable Lake Shore Drive, but it's far from the only one. He said he saw multiple crashes weekly, from minor fender-benders to fearsome wrecks that left vehicles in flames, during the four years he worked nights.

To rein in dangerous motor-

ists on Chicago's lakefront roadway, where a 40 mph speed limit is often seen only as a suggestion, North Side state Sen. Sara Feigenholtz is pushing for safety measures that could ultimately include the installation of AI-powered cameras aimed at not only catching speeders but track-

Turn to Study, Page 2

ANALYSIS

Trump's combativeness with courts is growing

Experts alarmed by defiance of rulings in deportation case

By Adam Liptak
The New York Times

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration's compliance with court orders started with foot-dragging, moved to semantic gymnastics and has now arrived at the cusp of outright defiance.

Large swaths of President Donald Trump's agenda have been tied up in court, challenged in scores of lawsuits. The administration has frozen money that the courts have ordered it to spend. It has blocked The Associated Press from the White House press pool despite a court order saying that the news organization

be allowed to participate. And it ignored a judge's instruction to return planes carrying Venezuelan immigrants bound for a notorious prison in El Salvador.

But Exhibit A in what legal scholars say is a deeply worrisome and escalating trend is the administration's combative response to the Supreme Court's ruling last week in the case of a Salvadoran immigrant. The administration deported Kilmar Armando Abrego Garcia to El Salvador despite a 2019 ruling from an immigration judge specifically and directly prohibiting that very thing.

Until recently, none of this was in dispute. "The United States acknowledges that Abrego Garcia was subject to a with-

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Easter feasts in Chicago

Explore 70 Chicago restaurant specials, from brunch buffets to hearty dinners. **Food & Health**

Report examines hospital charity

Many Illinois hospitals receive tax exemptions, but how much do they help their communities? **Business**

Haunted by the Heat

Maybe this is the year the Bulls finally beat Heat in a play-in tournament game. **Chicago Sports**

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Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 16

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